

The Value of location: What Matters Most for Older Adults Considering Relocation in Sweden?

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Abstract

We examined heterogeneity in housing preferences among older adults in Sweden using discrete choice experiment data ($n = 957$; mean age = 72; 55.3% women). Respondents assessed trade-offs between key residential attributes, including proximity to shops and services, green spaces, access to public transportation, dedicated parking, and planned monthly expenses. We estimated mixed logit models to recover marginal willingness to pay estimates for each attribute, including interactions with age, gender, and health to capture systematic variation in preferences. We identified meaningful differences between homeowners and renters, with homeowners consistently willing to pay more across all attributes, with the largest gap for parking, where their willingness to pay was approximately twice that of renters. Differences between gender and tenure status were identified, reflecting underlying patterns of social inequality in later life. These findings contribute policy-relevant evidence to support the development of age-inclusive housing strategies that address both diverse preferences and structural disparities in residential choice.

Keywords: stated choice; discrete choice; ageing in place; housing; housing preferences

Introduction

Population ageing is reshaping housing markets and welfare systems across much of the developed world. By 2050, the number of people aged 65 years or older is projected to more than double from 2021 levels, rising to 1.6 billion individuals globally (United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs, 2023). As the proportion of older adults continues to rise, policymakers face growing challenges in ensuring that housing and neighborhoods support autonomy, accessibility, and wellbeing in later life.

Although most older adults prefer to age in place, remaining in familiar environments rather than relocating to institutional care (Wiles et al., 2012; Abramsson & Andersson, 2015), life-course events and declining physical capacity often necessitate or motivate residential change. Understanding how older adults evaluate potential relocation alternatives is therefore essential for developing effective, age-inclusive housing strategies. As most existing research on such matters relies on qualitative data (Eriksson et al., 2022; Chaulagain, 2025) research based on larger samples and allowing for quantitative estimates, including economic aspects, has potential to generate useful and relevant knowledge.

Population ageing is also shaping the future demand for housing in terms of both quantity and suitability. Older adults spend a greater share of their time at home and rely on their residential environment for daily functioning, social contact, and wellbeing (De Jong et al., 2022). The concept of ageing in place has become central to housing policy across the world, emphasising the desire of older adults to remain in familiar surroundings for as long as possible (Grimmer et al., 2015). However, a key pillar of ageing in place depends on the suitability of existing housing and the availability of alternatives when relocation becomes necessary.

Relocation decisions in later life are shaped by a complex interplay of personal, social, and environmental factors (Roy et al., 2018). At older ages, maintaining a dwelling may become burdensome, while multi-level homes or inaccessible layouts may no longer fit changing functional abilities (Ewen et al., 2014). The departure of children or the loss of a partner can alter household needs and attachment to place (Abramsson & Andersson, 2012) while reduced mobility and increased social integration alter expectations of relocation (Robison & Moen, 2000; Eriksson et al., 2022). As the dwelling is typically the greatest source of a household's net worth, financial considerations, including the desire to release housing equity or lower housing costs after retirement, may also encourage relocation (Clark et al., 2006). Psychological factors such as loss aversion may further reinforce reluctance to move, as individuals weigh potential losses in comfort, familiarity, or community more heavily than prospective gains (Ossokina & Arentze, 2022). For example in Sweden, relocation rates among older adults remain low, reflecting strong place attachment, social ties, and perceived risks associated with moving (Abramsson & Andersson, 2015).

When relocations do occur, they inevitably involve evaluating a range of neighbourhood and accessibility attributes that influence daily life. The residential environment affects not only physical mobility and independence but also opportunities for social contact and recreation. These attributes can be understood as components of neighbourhood accessibility, broadly defined as the ease with which individuals can reach essential services, transport, and recreational environments. Older adults considering relocation therefore weigh multiple trade-offs among desirable housing attributes. For instance, some may prioritise proximity to green areas, while others place greater value on access to public transport or nearby shops and services. However, little

is known about what and how people prioritise among such attributes, and these preferences, along with their implicit trade-offs, are likely to vary across socio-demographic groups. Although housing preferences are widely studied, few stated preference studies quantify trade-offs in neighbourhood and locational attributes for older adults. Existing research often focuses on specific groups, with limited comparative evidence across tenure types among older individuals considering relocation. Much of the scientific literature has focused on life course transitions, housing tenure, and affordability (Damhuis & Van Gent, 2024; Lu & Kong, 2024), but few studies have quantified trade-offs among housing and locational characteristics.

One approach to quantify these preferences, the Discrete Choice Experiment (DCE), represents a specific and widely used form of stated choice methodology, enabling the assessment of important trade-offs that individuals make (Train, 2003). In this setting, respondents are presented with choice sets containing two or more alternatives that vary systematically across predefined attributes and select their preferred option in each set. The approach is rooted in random utility theory, which assumes that individuals choose the alternative that maximizes their utility based on observable attributes and unobserved factors (McFadden, 1974). By observing patterns of choice across multiple scenarios, researchers can infer the relative importance of different attributes and estimate willingness to pay values when a cost attribute is included. This capacity to quantify trade-offs makes DCE valuable in research on ageing and housing, where individuals must balance multiple, often competing, considerations such as cost, location, accessibility, and amenities.

While DCEs are increasingly applied in housing research, relatively few studies have explicitly focused on older populations, and even fewer have examined heterogeneity in locational preferences across tenure types within this demographic. Early studies focused primarily on environmental amenities and locational factors, such as proximity to green spaces, transit, and urban services (Earnhart, 2002; Cho et al., 2005; Liao et al., 2015). More recent work has integrated socio-demographic and behavioral factors to explore heterogeneity in preferences across population subgroups. For example, Caplan et al. (2021) examined residential preferences along Utah's Wasatch Front in the U.S. and found substantial variation in willingness to pay for amenities such as green space and access to transit. Similarly, Lee et al. (2025) analyzed willingness to pay for circular

and affordable housing among younger adults in South Korea, while Ardeshiri et al. (2024) used a dual DCE to distinguish between preferences for owner-occupied and investment properties in Sydney, Australia. Among the few studies framed in the context of aging, Ossokina et al. (2020) estimated a stated choice experiment to study the residential preferences of older homeowners in the Netherlands, reporting that residential attributes connecting to safety and social cohesion play an important role. They demonstrated that housing decisions among older homeowners are reference-dependent, showing how individuals value safety, accessibility, and social cohesion relative to their current housing situation.

Housing preferences are rarely uniform across individuals. Economic capacity, household composition, tenure status, and health conditions can all shape how people evaluate residential alternatives. Differences in tenure are closely linked to financial resources and housing market access, raising important questions about inequality in later-life residential choice. Studies have shown that income influences willingness to pay for proximity and comfort amenities, while tenure reflects differences in security, attachment, and investment orientation (Caplan et al., 2021; Ardeshiri et al., 2024). Ageing itself introduces new dimensions of heterogeneity, as physical ability, mobility, and social networks evolve over time (Lofqvist et al., 2013). To capture this systematic variation in empirical models, recent housing studies have incorporated interaction terms with latent class or mixed logit models in order to address preference heterogeneity (Caplan et al., 2021; Aitken et al., 2024; Schulz et al., 2025). Such methods are particularly suitable for studying diverse populations like older adults, whose housing preferences may differ systematically by age, health status, income, or tenure arrangement.

Despite these advances, the evidence base for older populations remains limited, and most findings are context specific, reflecting local housing systems and welfare regimes. Although recent studies incorporate more flexible models, most focus on limited heterogeneity or single tenure groups. As a result, evidence on how socio demographic factors shape locational preferences across renters and homeowners in later life remains limited. This gap is particularly consequential given the rapid ageing of populations across developed countries and the distinct housing systems that shape housing opportunities and constraints. Thus, there is a need to better understand how older people reason regarding housing and relocation and in this process, how different

attributes are valued. In particular, it remains unclear whether preferences for mobility-related attributes differ systematically from those for neighbourhood amenities, and how such differences vary across socio-demographic groups.

The aim of this study was to examine these residential trade-offs by estimating willingness to pay values of key locational and amenity attributes of older adults in Sweden who are considering relocation, including both renters and homeowners. Specifically, we assess how preferences for proximity to green areas, shops, public transport, and parking amenities vary by age, gender, health status, and tenure status. The focus on individuals actively considering relocation enhances the behavioural relevance of the stated choice data and distinguishes the study from existing literature that often relies purely on hypothetical preferences among those without immediate moving intentions.

Materials and Method

Using data from a DCE embedded in the Prospective RELOC-AGE study, we estimated mixed logit models to derive marginal willingness-to-pay (MWTP) estimates for proximity to green space, shops, and public transport, as well as for dedicated parking access. To examine observable preference heterogeneity, we incorporated interaction terms across age, gender, and health status, allowing us to identify systematic variation in how these attributes are valued. While random parameters in the mixed logit specification account for unobserved preference heterogeneity, the interaction terms isolate observed, socio-demographically driven variation in preferences.

The study builds on recent stated choice housing studies (Ossokina et al., 2020; Caplan et al., 2021; Ossokina & Arentze, 2022; Aitken et al., 2024; Lee et al., 2025), extending DCE methods to a Scandinavian context where ageing-in-place policies are well established but evidence on relocation preferences remains limited.

Participants and data collection

The primary objective of the ongoing Prospective RELOC-AGE project, a longitudinal two-tiered mixed-method cohort investigation conducted in Sweden, is to explore the long-term dynamics associated with housing choices, relocation, and active and healthy ageing, focusing on individuals across the ageing process. The project was registered under the identifier NCT04765696 on ClinicalTrials.gov (U.S. National Library of Medicine, 2021). At baseline (2021) eligible participants were individuals aged 55 or older, residing in Sweden, and actively registered with an interest in relocation with one of three housing companies: two local public housing providers and a national provider of tenant-owned dwellings. With

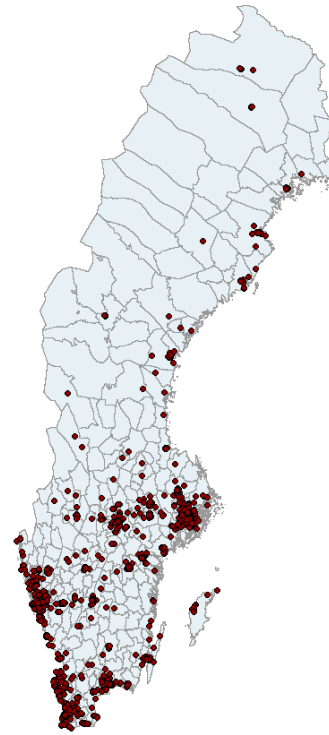


Figure 1
Location of DCE participants (N = 957)

>200 questions in each survey setting, the Prospective RELOC-AGE provides a rich source of information, including a wide set of socio-demographic information.

The DCE was administered in conjunction with the second follow-up survey administered during May to October 2024, where 1,247 respondents (64 % of the baseline cohort) agreed to participate in the Prospective RELOC-AGE survey via a web-based platform. After the main survey was completed, respondents were asked to continue and take part in the optional DCE. Following the initial DCE administration, two reminder emails were distributed. The final DCE sample size consisted of 957 individuals, representing a 73% response rate of the follow-up survey respondents. They represented a geographically diverse sample of individuals aged 55 and above across Sweden (Figure 1).

Prior to administering the DCE we conducted an internal review (n =20) and a pilot study to review the experiment (n = 56). The internal review involved researchers and staff within the research team's network. The pilot study was administered to

participants in the Stakeholder Pool, a network of older individuals with an interest in collaborating with academia in research on ageing and health, which has been established at the Centre for Ageing and Supportive Environments (CASE) at Lund University. The similar demographics between the survey respondents and participants in the Stakeholder Pool were important for refining the experiment. In both phases, the participants completed the experiment and a structured feedback form assessing the relevance of attributes, clarity of wording and levels, and overall task comprehension and burden. Feedback was instrumental in refining the experiment and clarifying the descriptions and wording of the instructions. We made several informed revisions: clarifying attribute descriptions and levels; removing redundant instructional text; fine-tuning attribute levels; and reducing the number of choice sets to manage respondent burden. The final DCE questionnaire included three parts: an introduction to the experiment including definitions of the attributes and levels, a short questionnaire on household income, costs, and planned future housing costs, and the actual experiment with nine choice sets.

Ethics

The Prospective RELOC-AGE project was approved by the Swedish Ethical Review Authority (nos. 2020–03457; 2022-01287-02; 2024-01696-02), in alignment with the Declaration of Helsinki and current national ethical regulations for research involving human participants. Potential participants received written information highlighting that participation was voluntary and that declining would not affect their access to housing options or public services. Informed consent was considered given upon the completion and return of the survey.

Experiment design

Stated choice experiments encompass a range of techniques in which respondents indicate their preferences by explicitly stating their choices and allow for the evaluation of decisions in a controlled setting (Lancsar & Louviere, 2008). This enables researchers to systematically manipulate attributes and isolate the impact of specific factors on decision-making (Hensher et al., 2015). A DCE is a type of stated preference experiment that presents individuals with hypothetical scenarios, allowing researchers

to quantify how much value respondents place on different attributes of a product, service, or in the case of this study, a housing option.

Our respondents were asked to choose the most desirable housing option from a set of alternatives containing varying levels of attributes. The choice of attributes and associated levels was guided by a combination of factors identified from the Prospective RELOC-AGE follow-up study and attributes identified in the literature. Green space proximity has been examined in numerous contexts including improved cardiometabolic and general health (Maas, 2006; Paquet et al., 2013), lower stress (Nielsen & Hansen, 2007), and improved mental health (Sturm & Cohen, 2014; Cohen-Cline et al., 2015). The attribute greenspace was defined as the distance in kilometers to green areas including parks, forests, hiking areas, and open spaces. Proximity to shops and services represents not only distance to frequent amenities that may become more burdensome to traverse with age but also constitutes an integral social experience to participate in the social life of communities (Lucas et al. 2016). The attribute shops represented the distance to shopping amenities such as grocery stores, malls, boutiques, and shopping centers. The attribute transport was defined as the distance to public transportation, such as a bus stop, metro station, or train station. Access to public transportation has been shown to affect accessibility levels of populations, with significant differences identified in older cohorts (Alsnih & Hensher, 2003; Ricciardi et al., 2015). Parking availability may also affect acceptability, particularly for the Prospective RELOC-AGE sample where >90% indicated access to an automobile. Cost was specified as a percentage change from respondent's planned monthly housing cost, which was asked for in the first part of the survey. When conducting the experiment, we customized the questions to be adaptive, utilizing each respondent's "Planned future housing cost" value to calculate the relative cost, in addition to the presented percentage change when presenting the choice sets. For example, if a respondent stated 10,000 SEK in planned monthly costs, the 10% more option would display: "Option #2 Cost: 10% more than planned costs (11000 SEK/month total)" Table 1 presents the attributes with their corresponding levels.

Table 1
Attributes and their corresponding levels used in the experiment

Attribute	Levels
Distance to green areas	500 m; 5 km; 15 km
Distance to shops and services	500 m; 5 km; 15 km
Distance to public transportation	300 m; 600 m; 900 m
Parking availability	None; Reserved space; Reserved garage
Monthly housing cost (vs. planned)	−20%; −10%; 0%; +10%; +20%

Before commencing the experiment, respondents were given a definition of each attribute, as well as an example to minimize any ambiguity in interpretation. They were also instructed to base each choice on the assumption that the alternative housing options were identical in every way aside from the attributes presented.

When designing a DCE, including every combination of attribute levels in the construction of the choice sets (i.e., a full factorial design) is often too large to be used in practice. To reduce the dimensionality of a full factorial design, a D-optimal subset was generated using the R package cbc tools (Helveston, 2025) which reduced dimensionality while maintaining statistical power and balanced attribute representation. The number of choice sets was limited to nine to minimize the cognitive burden while maximizing the statistical power (DeShazo & Fermo, 2002; Mangham et al., 2009; Himmler et al., 2021). No opt out option was included, as all respondents had already expressed an intention to relocate and were therefore actively considering alternative housing options. Figure 2 depicts a typical choice set presented to the respondents.

If these were the only housing options available to you and differ only by the attributes shown, which would you choose?

Option 1	Option 2
	
Distance to green area: 10km	Distance to green area: 5km
Distance to shops: 5km	Distance to shops: 15km
Distance to transportation : 300m	Distance to transportation : 900m
Parking: No reserved parking	Parking: Garage parking
Price: 10% more	Price: 10% less

Figure 2
Example of choice set

Statistical analysis

Respondent's choices were modelled within the random utility theory framework, which assumes individuals choose options which maximize their utility based upon available options (Lancsar & Louviere, 2008). An underlying utility model can then be estimated where the utility that individual i derives from alternative j in a choice set t is given by:

$$U_{itj} = V_{itj} + \varepsilon_{itj} \quad (1)$$

where V_{itj} is the systematic component of utility, modelled as a function of the attributes of the alternative, and ε_{itj} is an unobserved random error term. The systematic utility is specified as:

$$V_{itj} = \beta_1 X_{itj} + \beta_2 X_{itj} + \dots + \beta_k X_{itjk} \quad (2)$$

where X_{itjk} represents the level of attribute k for alternative j in task t , and β_k are the corresponding utility coefficients to be estimated.

Under the multinomial logit (MNL) model, preferences are assumed to be homogeneous across respondents and the error terms ε_{itj} are independently and identically distributed (i.i.d.). The probability that individual i chooses alternative j in task t is then:

$$P_{itj} = \Pr(y_{it} = j) = \frac{\exp(V_{itj})}{\sum_j \exp(V_{itj})} \quad (3)$$

While MNL models are commonly used in choice modelling, they are not well suited to uncover heterogeneity in preferences related to observable characteristics, which was a central aim of our study. Recent housing studies address this limitation by allowing utility coefficients to vary across individuals or groups (Ardeshiri et al., 2024; Aitken et al., 2024; Lee et al., 2025). We followed this line of research and estimated mixed logit (ML) models, in which the utility coefficients β_i are allowed to vary randomly across individuals to account for unobserved heterogeneity in preferences (McFadden & Train, 2000). Instead of assuming that all individuals share the same preference parameters, the mixed logit model allows each respondent to have their own vector of utility coefficients. These individual-specific coefficients are treated as random draws from a population distribution with a mean vector β and a covariance matrix Σ . The mean vector represents the average preferences in the sample, while the covariance matrix captures the extent to which preferences vary across individuals and the degree to which these random parameters may be correlated with one another.

The mixed logit model captures heterogeneity by integrating over the distribution of random coefficients using maximum simulated likelihood

$$P_{itj} = \int \frac{\exp(V_{itj}(\beta_i))}{\sum_l \exp(V_{itl}(\beta_i))} f(\beta_i | \beta, \Sigma) d\beta_i \quad (4)$$

Because this integral has no closed-form solution, it was approximated using simulation. The simulated choice probability for an alternative is then obtained by averaging these draw-specific probabilities across all simulation draws. The log-likelihood function is constructed from these simulated probabilities by matching them to the alternatives chosen by each respondent across all choice tasks. This simulated log-likelihood is then maximized to recover the mean coefficients and covariance parameters of the mixed logit model. In our application, all non-monetary attributes were specified as random with independent normal distributions, while the cost coefficient was fixed to ensure consistent derivation of willingness to pay measures. We

allowed the random parameters to be fully correlated, enabling the model to capture systematic relationships in preferences across attributes. Models were estimated in R using the logitr package (Helveston, 2023) using 1000 Sobol draws and multiple random starting values to ensure convergence to the global maximum (Train, 2003).

We then used the cost coefficient to compute monetary trade-offs for non-cost attributes. First, we estimated the mean marginal rate of substitution (MRS) for each attribute, where the MRS for attribute k was calculated as:

$$MRS_k = - \frac{\hat{\beta}_k}{\hat{\beta}_{cost}} \quad (5)$$

Where $\hat{\beta}_{cost}$ is the estimated coefficient on the cost attribute. To account for interaction terms with socio-demographic variables, the MRS for attribute k and individual characteristic z was calculated as:

$$MRS_{kz} = - \frac{\hat{\beta}_k + \hat{\beta}_{k,z}}{\hat{\beta}_{cost} + \hat{\beta}_{cost,z}} \quad (6)$$

We followed (Caplan et al., 2021) to estimate willingness to pay values. As the cost attribute was specified as a percentage change from the respondent's expected housing cost in 10 % intervals, we converted marginal rates of substitution (MRS) into marginal willingness to pay (MWTP) in monetary terms by scaling with 10 % of the mean reported monthly housing cost:

$$MWTP_k = MRS_k \times 0.10 \times Planned\ Cost \quad (7)$$

where *Planned Cost* denotes the mean of respondents' stated planned monthly housing cost, captured in the DCE questionnaire. These MWTP estimates represent the amount, in SEK per month, that respondents are willing to pay for improvements in each housing attribute, relative to their planned future housing costs.

We first estimated mixed logit models separately for homeowners and renters to identify preference patterns across housing tenures. Positive (negative) coefficients indicate increases (decreases) in average utility relative to the reference level of each

attribute. Reference levels were defined as the least preferred option, such that estimated coefficients are expected to be positive where improvements are valued.

Next, we estimated interaction models to examine whether preferences vary systematically across key socio-demographic characteristics: gender, age, and self-reported health. For each characteristic, a separate mixed logit model was estimated in which all attribute levels were interacted with an indicator variable for the relevant group. For example, in the gender model, a dummy variable equal to one for men was interacted with each attribute. In this specification, the main effects represent preferences for the reference group (women), while the interaction terms indicate how the preferences of the comparison group (men) deviate from those of the reference group. Analogous models were estimated for age, using a dummy equal to one for respondents above the sample median age, and for health, using a dummy equal to one for respondents reporting good or better health. To aid interpretation, we converted the estimated coefficients into MWTP values using the approach described above. MWTP expresses the monetary value respondents placed on marginal improvements in each attribute, relative to its reference level. For models including interactions, MWTP values were computed separately for each subgroup using the appropriate combination of main and interaction coefficients. Thus, these estimates provide an interpretable monetary metric for comparing preferences across socio-demographic groups. We computed confidence intervals using the delta method, allowing formal tests of whether estimates, differ from zero (Wooldridge, 2010).

Results

Sample characteristics

Of the 957 respondents, 790 were homeowners and 167 were renters. The sample was slightly majority female (55.3%), with most participants aged 65–74 years (43.5%) followed by those aged 75+ (36.5%). Most respondents were partnered (60.6%), retired (77.1%), and lived in apartments or condominium housing (63.0%). Most had attained at least three years of university education (47.6%) and lived in city or town locations (62.2%). Slightly more than half of the respondents described their health as “Very good” or better (50.04%). Households predominantly consisted of one or two members

(95.2%), with 3.8% reporting three or more. The mean monthly household income was 52,000 SEK, and the average planned monthly housing cost was 10,000 SEK. Table 2 provides descriptive statistics for the study sample, disaggregated by housing tenure.

Table 2 –Sample characteristics by tenure type (N = 790 for homeowners, N = 167 for renters)

	Owner (N=790)	Renter (N=167)	Overall (N=957)	P-value
Sex				
Female	419 (53.0%)	110 (65.9%)	529 (55.3%)	0.00324
Male	371 (47.0%)	57 (34.1%)	428 (44.7%)	
Age group				
55-64	154 (19.5%)	38 (22.8%)	192 (20.1%)	0.595
65-74	344 (43.5%)	72 (43.1%)	416 (43.5%)	
75+	292 (37.0%)	57 (34.1%)	349 (36.5%)	
Civil status				
Not partnered	287 (36.3%)	90 (53.9%)	377 (39.4%)	<0.001
Partnered	503 (63.7%)	77 (46.1%)	580 (60.6%)	
Education				
Elementary school	42 (5.3%)	17 (10.2%)	59 (6.2%)	0.0618
2 years upper secondary	68 (8.6%)	17 (10.2%)	85 (8.9%)	
3-4 years upper secondary	127 (16.1%)	30 (18.0%)	157 (16.4%)	
University < 3 years	161 (20.4%)	37 (22.2%)	198 (20.7%)	
University >= 3 years	390 (49.4%)	66 (39.5%)	456 (47.6%)	
Missing	2 (0.3%)	0 (0%)	2 (0.2%)	
Self-reported health				
Poor	13 (1.6%)	4 (2.4%)	17 (1.8%)	0.225
Fairly	118 (14.9%)	35 (21.0%)	153 (16.0%)	
Good	249 (31.5%)	53 (31.7%)	302 (31.6%)	
Very good	283 (35.8%)	48 (28.7%)	331 (34.6%)	
Excellent	126 (15.9%)	25 (15.0%)	151 (15.8%)	
Missing	1 (0.1%)	2 (1.2%)	3 (0.3%)	
Retired				
Yes	612 (77.5%)	126 (75.4%)	738 (77.1%)	0.565
No	174 (22.0%)	41 (24.6%)	215 (22.5%)	
Missing	4 (0.5%)	0 (0%)	4 (0.4%)	
Housing type				
Apartment/Condo	449 (56.8%)	154 (92.2%)	603 (63.0%)	<0.001
House	341 (43.2%)	13 (7.8%)	354 (37.0%)	
Housing location				
City/town	478 (60.5%)	117 (70.1%)	595 (62.2%)	0.193
Urban/countryside	221 (28.0%)	41 (24.6%)	262 (27.4%)	
Missing	91 (11.5%)	9 (5.4%)	100 (10.4%)	
Number in household				
1	240 (30.4%)	81 (48.5%)	321 (33.5%)	<0.001
2	509 (64.4%)	81 (48.5%)	590 (61.7%)	
3 or more	34 (4.3%)	2 (1.2%)	36 (3.8%)	
Missing	7 (0.9%)	3 (1.8%)	10 (1.0%)	
Monthly household income (SEK)				
Mean (SD)	55000 (32000)	42000 (26000)	52000 (31000)	<0.001
Median [Min, Max]	50000 [2000, 220000]	37000 [2000, 150000]	45000 [2000, 220000]	
Planned monthly housing cost (SEK)				
Mean (SD)	10000 (4100)	10000 (5600)	10000 (4400)	0.943
Median [Min, Max]	10000 [3000, 40000]	9000 [3000, 60000]	10000 [3000, 60000]	

Standard model results

Table 3 presents the results from the standard mixed logit models estimated separately for renters and homeowners. A positive(negative) coefficient estimate indicates and increase(decrease) in the average respondent's utility level. Across both tenure groups, the estimated coefficients display the expected signs and are generally highly statistically significant. Significant standard deviations reported in columns three and five provides evidence of unobserved heterogeneity in the samples.

Table 3 – Mixed logit results: Renters and Owners

Attribute	Owners		Renters	
	Coefficient	SD	Coefficient	SD
Green space: 5 km (vs 15 km)	1.02*** (0.11)	0.50* (0.24)	2.26*** (0.58)	-0.94** (0.33)
Green space: 500 m (vs 15 km)	2.02*** (0.15)	-0.67 (0.39)	3.67*** (0.70)	-0.90* (0.46)
Shops: 5 km (vs 15 km)	0.93*** (0.13)	0.43 (0.31)	1.82** (0.57)	1.17* (0.55)
Shops: 500 m (vs 15 km)	3.04*** (0.18)	0.58 (0.46)	4.32*** (0.63)	0.20 (0.51)
Transit stop: 600 m (vs 900 m)	0.38*** (0.11)	-0.15 (0.26)	0.49 (0.31)	-0.10 (0.34)
Transit stop: 300 m (vs 900 m)	1.15*** (0.13)	0.79*** (0.22)	1.42*** (0.30)	0.33 (0.40)
Parking: reserved garage (vs none)	2.98*** (0.19)	-0.94*** (0.21)	2.70*** (0.44)	1.06** (0.35)
Parking: reserved space (vs none)	2.43*** (0.17)	2.27*** (0.19)	2.64*** (0.43)	2.68*** (0.52)
Cost	-5.08*** (0.35)		-9.54*** (1.25)	
Num. obs.	7110		1458	
Log Likelihood	-3156.61		-616.04	
AIC	6403.22		1322.09	
BIC	6712.33		1559.91	
McFadden R ²	0.36		0.39	
LR χ^2 (df=45)	3543.33***		789.13***	

***p < 0.001; **p < 0.01; *p < 0.05

Note: Coefficients estimated from mixed logit models using simulated maximum likelihood. Standard errors in parenthesis.

The monetary MWTP estimates valuations derived from these coefficients are reported in Table 4 along with 95% confidence intervals. Among homeowners, MWTP values

indicate substantial willingness to pay for improved accessibility and amenities. For example, homeowners were willing to pay 397 SEK and 598 SEK per month to live within 500 meters, instead of 15 km, from the nearest green area and shops, respectively. Parking amenities were highly valued. Compared to no reserved parking, respondents were willing to pay 587 SEK for a reserved garage space and 478 SEK for reserved parking space.

Renters reveal similar preference patterns but with generally lower MWTP magnitudes. Renters were willing to pay 346 SEK per month to reside within 500 m of green space and 408 SEK for proximity to shops within 500 meters. These values remain economically meaningful yet modestly below those of owners. Renters also show strong preferences for parking access, although their MWTP for a reserved garage (254 SEK) or space (249 SEK) is roughly half that of homeowners.

Table 4 – MWTP Estimates: Renters and Owners

Attribute	Owners	Renters
Green space: 5 km (vs 15 km)	200 (152, 248)	214 (110, 318)
Green space: 500 m (vs 15 km)	397 (330, 464)	346 (223, 469)
Shops: 5 km (vs 15 km)	184 (125, 243)	171 (63, 279)
Shops: 500 m (vs 15 km)	598 (514, 682)	408 (300, 516)
Transit stop: 600 m (vs 900 m)	74 (31, 117)	46 (-14, 106)
Transit stop: 300 m (vs 900 m)	227 (175, 279)	134 (78, 190)
Parking: reserved garage (vs none)	587 (502, 672)	254 (183, 325)
Parking: reserved space (vs none)	478 (414, 542)	249 (186, 312)

Note: MWTP in SEK/month (10% of median monthly housing cost: owners 10,000 SEK, renters 9,000 SEK). 95% confidence intervals in parentheses, estimated via delta method. EUR/SEK exchange rate as of May 31st, 2024 was 1 EUR = 11.42 SEK.

Observed heterogeneity model results

Age Models

Table 5 tabulates the mixed logit results, which include age interactions with the attributes. Among homeowners below the median age of 72, proximity to amenities generated strong and statistically significant utility gains, with MWTPs of 385 SEK for green space within 500 m, 533 SEK for shops within 500 m, and 515 SEK for a reserved garage. For older homeowners, the positive $Cost \times Age$ interaction (1.51, $p < 0.01$) indicates that older homeowners are less cost sensitive, while two interactions reached statistical significance. First, the $Transit \times Age$ interaction suggests older homeowners place greater value on proximity to a transit stop at 600 m, with a MWTP of 136 SEK compared to 15 SEK for younger homeowners. Second, the $Green\ space \times Age$ interaction suggests differences in green space preference, however this results in only marginal differences in MWTP. Remaining interaction terms, including shops, and parking, did not reach conventional significance levels, suggesting that preferences for these attributes are broadly similar across age groups among homeowners. Among renters, no age interactions were statistically significant, with the exception of shops at 500 m, indicating that older renters place somewhat less value on very close proximity to shops than their younger counterparts.

Table 5- Interaction Regression - Age

Attribute	Owners		Renters	
	Coef.	MWTP	Coef.	MWTP
Green space: 5 km (vs 15 km)	1.08*** (0.15)	183.48*** (28.80)	2.22*** (0.67)	174.20*** (49.83)
Green space: 500 m (vs 15 km)	2.26*** (0.20)	385.37*** (40.77)	3.99*** (0.86)	312.91*** (57.89)
Shops: 5 km (vs 15 km)	0.95*** (0.17)	161.89*** (35.17)	1.96** (0.67)	153.71** (55.71)
Shops: 500 m (vs 15 km)	3.13*** (0.22)	532.62*** (48.25)	5.45*** (0.98)	427.66*** (59.73)
Transit stop: 600 m (vs 900 m)	0.09 (0.14)	15.38 (24.82)	0.72 (0.42)	56.91 (35.27)
Transit stop: 300 m (vs 900 m)	1.04*** (0.16)	177.02*** (29.80)	1.53*** (0.43)	119.79*** (33.25)
Parking: reserved garage (vs none)	3.02*** (0.23)	514.79*** (48.45)	2.79*** (0.58)	218.85*** (40.22)
Parking: reserved space (vs none)	2.24*** (0.20)	380.96*** (35.42)	3.02*** (0.67)	236.91*** (41.11)
Cost	-5.87*** (0.49)		-11.46*** (2.16)	
Green space: 5 km (vs 15 km) × Age	-0.16 (0.19)	211.09*** (37.26)	0.24 (0.77)	240.69*** (66.49)
Green space: 500 m (vs 15 km) × Age	-0.57* (0.24)	389.33*** (51.22)	-0.23 (0.83)	366.93*** (77.70)
Shops: 5 km (vs 15 km) × Age	-0.01 (0.22)	215.83*** (47.45)	-0.85 (0.80)	108.40 (63.20)
Shops: 500 m (vs 15 km) × Age	-0.23 (0.24)	663.61*** (68.96)	-1.94* (0.82)	343.34*** (61.42)
Transit stop: 600 m (vs 900 m) × Age	0.50** (0.20)	136.49*** (37.00)	-0.49 (0.58)	23.09 (41.74)
Transit stop: 300 m (vs 900 m) × Age	0.10 (0.21)	260.27*** (41.86)	-0.00 (0.56)	148.83*** (42.73)
Parking: reserved garage (vs none) × Age	-0.10 (0.27)	670.92*** (71.94)	-0.51 (0.64)	223.12*** (48.42)
Parking: reserved space (vs none) × Age	0.28 (0.25)	576.74*** (56.19)	-0.31 (0.73)	264.38*** (50.28)
Cost × Old (age ≥72)	1.51** (0.58)		2.26 (1.91)	
Num. obs.	7110		1458	
Log Likelihood	-3143.01		-623.13	
AIC	6394.01		1354.26	
BIC	6764.95		1639.64	
McFadden R ²	0.36		0.38	
LR χ^2 (df=54)	3570.54***		774.96***	

***p < 0.001; **p < 0.01; *p < 0.05

Note: Estimation by maximum likelihood of the mixed logit model. Standard errors reported in parentheses. MWTP are calculated as described in the main text. Age is a dummy variable equal to one if age is greater or equal to 72, the median age of the sample.

Gender models

As shown in Table 6, female homeowners had strong and statistically significant preferences for proximity-based amenities. Among homeowners, five gender interaction terms reached statistical significance. Women placed greater value on green space proximity (478 SEK vs 313 SEK to be within 500 m) and transit access (288 SEK vs 157 SEK for a stop within 300 m). Men, by contrast, placed significantly higher value on parking, with MWTPs of 624 SEK (garage) and 518 SEK (reserved space) compared with 550 SEK and 430 SEK for women. A modest significant interaction was also observed for shops at 5 km, with men expressing slightly higher preference. Among renters, no gender interaction terms were statistically significant. While MWTP magnitudes for male renters appear higher for some attributes, notably shops (510 SEK vs 366 SEK), these differences are not statistically distinguishable from zero and should therefore not be interpreted as evidence of systematic gender differences among renters.

Table 6 - Interaction Regression - Sex

Attribute	Owners		Renters	
	Coef.	MWTP	Coef.	MWTP
Green space: 5 km (vs 15 km)	0.94*** (0.14)	195.19*** (33.34)	1.86** (0.59)	154.64*** (46.94)
Green space: 500 m (vs 15 km)	2.31*** (0.19)	477.52*** (51.40)	3.89*** (0.84)	323.81*** (57.65)
Shops: 5 km (vs 15 km)	0.73*** (0.16)	151.11*** (39.34)	2.01** (0.66)	167.24** (53.84)
Shops: 500 m (vs 15 km)	2.99*** (0.22)	617.91*** (59.26)	4.40*** (0.87)	366.19*** (48.12)
Transit stop: 600 m (vs 900 m)	0.49*** (0.14)	100.38** (31.86)	0.72* (0.35)	59.96* (30.40)
Transit stop: 300 m (vs 900 m)	1.39*** (0.16)	288.20*** (38.84)	1.95*** (0.47)	162.37*** (36.57)
Parking: reserved garage (vs none)	2.66*** (0.22)	549.91*** (57.31)	2.72*** (0.58)	225.97*** (40.60)
Parking: reserved space (vs none)	2.08*** (0.19)	429.79*** (42.80)	2.93*** (0.65)	244.03*** (37.69)
Cost	-4.83*** (0.43)		-10.81*** (2.02)	
Green space: 5 km (vs 15 km) × Men	0.19 (0.19)	206.81*** (32.19)	1.08 (0.81)	299.84*** (86.39)
Green space: 500 m (vs 15 km) × Men	-0.59* (0.23)	312.81*** (40.88)	-0.15 (0.85)	381.45*** (98.74)
Shops: 5 km (vs 15 km) × Men	0.45* (0.22)	215.26*** (41.45)	-0.28 (0.85)	176.00 (90.31)
Shops: 500 m (vs 15 km) × Men	0.19 (0.24)	577.62*** (55.49)	0.60 (0.79)	509.86*** (106.10)
Transit stop: 600 m (vs 900 m) × Men	-0.24 (0.20)	44.38 (28.44)	-0.44 (0.63)	28.67 (55.98)
Transit stop: 300 m (vs 900 m) × Men	-0.53* (0.22)	156.90*** (32.82)	-1.07 (0.65)	89.40 (50.72)
Parking: reserved garage (vs none) × Men	0.77** (0.27)	624.25*** (59.35)	-0.08 (0.71)	268.26*** (71.81)
Parking: reserved space (vs none) × Men	0.77** (0.25)	518.27*** (45.53)	-0.49 (0.77)	249.13*** (61.19)
Cost × Men	-0.66 (0.58)		1.99 (1.95)	
Num. obs.	7110		1458	
Log Likelihood	-3140.82		-620.70	
AIC	6389.63		1349.40	
BIC	6760.57		1634.78	
McFadden R ²	0.36		0.39	
LR χ^2 (df=54)	3574.92***		779.82***	

Note: ***p < 0.001; **p < 0.01; *p < 0.05

Health models

In Table 7, we present the results for tests including interactions terms of attributes and health. For homeowners, two health interaction terms reached statistical significance. Those in good or better health placed greater value on green space proximity (416 SEK vs 293 SEK at 500 m). Conversely, respondents in fair or poor health placed considerably greater value on proximity to public transport: a MWTP of 164 SEK at 600 m compared with 47 SEK among those in good health. A similar pattern was observed among renters, where those in better health expressed a MWTP of 93 SEK for a transit stop within 300 m, compared with 252 SEK for those in fair or poor health. The remaining interaction terms, including shops and parking, did not reach conventional significance levels across either tenure group.

Table 7 - Interaction Regression - Health

	Owners		Renters	
	Coef.	MWTP	Coef.	MWTP
Green space: 5 km (vs 15 km)	0.73** (0.23)	146.68** (51.83)	1.24 (0.81)	115.64 (76.47)
Green space: 500 m (vs 15 km)	1.47*** (0.29)	292.75*** (71.61)	2.69** (1.01)	251.69** (95.03)
Shops: 5 km (vs 15 km)	1.10*** (0.27)	220.13** (71.01)	1.71 (1.04)	160.01 (106.43)
Shops: 500 m (vs 15 km)	2.74*** (0.31)	548.05*** (89.15)	5.10*** (1.19)	476.56*** (113.59)
Transit stop: 600 m (vs 900 m)	0.82*** (0.23)	164.14** (56.61)	0.91 (0.66)	85.13 (67.28)
Transit stop: 300 m (vs 900 m)	1.46*** (0.28)	291.50*** (67.38)	2.70*** (0.76)	251.97*** (70.95)
Parking: reserved garage (vs none)	2.97*** (0.35)	594.41*** (101.50)	2.44** (0.80)	228.34** (77.97)
Parking: reserved space (vs none)	2.57*** (0.33)	512.79*** (81.31)	2.75** (0.95)	256.48*** (75.28)
Cost	-5.00*** (0.74)		-9.64*** (2.46)	
Green space: 5 km (vs 15 km) × Very good health	0.35 (0.25)	211.37*** (26.31)	1.43 (0.99)	223.43*** (47.86)
Green space: 500 m (vs 15 km) × Very good health	0.67* (0.31)	416.12*** (36.93)	1.60 (1.15)	359.62*** (58.16)
Shops: 5 km (vs 15 km) × Very good health	-0.20 (0.29)	176.21*** (31.66)	0.18 (1.13)	158.42** (51.69)
Shops: 500 m (vs 15 km) × Very good health	0.28 (0.31)	590.28*** (44.85)	-0.48 (0.98)	386.53*** (51.68)
Transit stop: 600 m (vs 900 m) × Very good health	-0.58* (0.25)	47.26* (23.03)	-0.61 (0.76)	24.92 (31.57)
Transit stop: 300 m (vs 900 m) × Very good health	-0.40 (0.29)	206.34*** (27.37)	-1.58* (0.79)	93.34** (31.00)
Parking: reserved garage (vs none) × Very good health	-0.01 (0.36)	579.21*** (45.52)	0.13 (0.82)	215.53*** (34.39)
Parking: reserved space (vs none) × Very good health	-0.19 (0.34)	464.21*** (34.39)	0.24 (0.96)	249.64*** (36.25)
Cost × Very good health	-0.12 (0.78)		-1.12 (2.47)	
Num. obs.	7101		1440	
Log Likelihood	-3142.92		-616.86	
AIC	6393.85		1341.71	
BIC	6764.72		1626.42	
McFadden R ²	0.36		0.38	
LR χ^2 (df=54)	3558.23***		762.55***	

Note: *** p < 0.001; ** p < 0.01; * p < 0.05

Discussion

This study provides new evidence on how older adults in Sweden value housing and neighbourhood attributes when considering relocation. Using a DCE embedded in the Prospective RELOC-AGE project, we identify strong preferences for neighbourhood accessibility and reveal meaningful heterogeneity across tenure, age, gender, and health. The findings extend prior behavioural housing research by quantifying trade-offs older adults are willing to make, rather than relying on descriptive or revealed-preference approaches that may be restricted due to data limitations.

Across both tenure groups, all non-cost attributes attracted positive coefficients, confirming that respondents systematically preferred locations with closer proximity to green areas, shops, and public transportation, as well as access to reserved parking. The negative and significant cost coefficient aligns with theoretical expectations, confirming that higher monthly housing costs reduce utility. The statistically significant standard deviation estimates for many random parameters provide strong evidence of unobserved preference heterogeneity in the sample, justifying the mixed logit specification over simpler models.

Homeowners were willing to pay substantially more than renters across all attributes. For example, homeowners valued proximity to shops within 500 m at 598 SEK per month compared with 408 SEK for renters, and proximity to green space at 397 SEK compared with 346 SEK. The gap is most pronounced for parking: homeowner MWTP for a reserved garage or parking space reached 478–587 SEK, roughly double the corresponding renter values of 249–254 SEK. These differences are consistent with the broader literature linking tenure status to divergent housing priorities, resource constraints, and investment orientations (Caplan et al., 2021; Ardeshiri et al., 2024). That renters display economically meaningful but systematically lower valuations across all attributes may reflect tighter budget constraints or a different relationship with the residential environment, rather than weaker underlying preferences.

Age-related differences in preferences are present but modest. Among homeowners, the positive and significant $\text{Cost} \times \text{Age}$ interaction term suggests that older homeowners are

less cost sensitive, while the Transit stop $\times$ Age interaction indicates that those above the median age of 72 place greater value on public transport proximity, with a MWTP of 136 SEK per month for a transit stop within 300 meters compared with 15 SEK for younger homeowners. Preferences for green space remain broadly stable across age groups. This pattern is consistent with the sustained valuation of green space and its continued role in supporting physical activity, wellbeing, and mental health across the ageing spectrum (Paquet et al., 2013; Cohen-Cline et al., 2015; Landby & Kristin Godtman Kling, 2025). By contrast, preferences for shops and parking did not differ significantly across age groups of homeowners, suggesting that the broad appeal of these attributes is sustained across the ageing spectrum. For renters, only proximity to shops was found to be statistically significant, with older renters willing to pay 84 SEK a month less (343 vs 427 SEK) to be in close proximity to shops, a possible reflection of changing consumption patterns as individuals age (Berg & Liljedal, 2022). Taken together, these findings indicate that ageing shapes access-related preferences more strongly than amenity valuation itself.

Gender differences in housing preferences are concentrated among homeowners and attribute-specific. Five interaction terms reached statistical significance in the homeowner model. Female homeowners placed greater value on green space proximity, expressing a MWTP of 478 SEK per month for a location within 500 m of a green space, compared with 313 SEK for men. Female homeowners also valued transit access to a greater extent, with a MWTP of 288 SEK for a stop within 300 m compared with 157 SEK for male homeowners. Male homeowners, by contrast, placed significantly higher value on parking amenities, with MWTPs of 624 SEK for a reserved garage and 518 SEK for a reserved space, compared with 550 SEK and 430 SEK for women. A modest but significant interaction was also observed for shops at 5 km, with men expressing slightly stronger preferences. These gendered patterns are consistent with findings showing broader differences in mobility behaviour, with women more reliant on active and public transport and men more likely to prioritise car-based accessibility (Polk, 2004; Rosenbloom, 2006; Scheiner & Holz-Rau, 2017). Among renters, no gender interaction terms were statistically significant. While MWTP magnitudes for male renters appear higher for some attributes, notably shops (510 SEK vs 366 SEK), these differences are statistically inconclusive and should not be interpreted as evidence of systematic gender differences within this subgroup. Overall, the results suggest that

gendered residential preferences exist but are concentrated among homeowners, potentially reflecting differences in financial resources, car ownership, and mobility patterns that are more pronounced in that tenure group.

Health status shapes preferences in substantively meaningful but relatively targeted ways. Among homeowners, two interaction terms reached statistical significance. Those in good or better health placed greater value on green space proximity, with a MWTP of 416 SEK per month for a location within 500 m, compared with 293 SEK among those in fair or poor health. This pattern is consistent with established evidence linking access to green environments to physical activity, cardiometabolic health, and general wellbeing (Maas, 2006; Paquet et al., 2013) as well as to reduced stress and to support mental health (Nielsen & Hansen, 2007; Sturm & Cohen, 2014; Cohen-Cline et al., 2015). Here, better health may enable greater engagement with outdoor environments, thereby increasing the utility derived from nearby green space. Conversely, individuals in poorer health may face functional limitations that restrict their ability to use such environments, reducing the marginal value of proximity despite its potential benefits. The reverse pattern is observed for transport access. Homeowners in fair or poor health expressed a MWTP of 164 SEK for a stop within 600 m (relative to 900 m), compared with 47 SEK among those in better health. A similar pattern was observed among renters, where those in poorer health placed substantially higher value on close transport access (252 vs 93 SEK for a transit stop within 300 m). This pattern is consistent with evidence that declining health increases reliance on accessible public transport (Alsnih & Hensher, 2003; Mollenkopf et al., 2004). Conversely, better health supports greater engagement with outdoor environments, amplifying the value placed on green space proximity. The remaining interaction terms, including shops and parking across both tenure groups, did not reach conventional significance levels. Rather than indicating an absence of health-related differences, this suggests that the influence of health status is concentrated in attributes most directly linked to physical mobility and environmental engagement, rather than uniformly shaping all aspects of residential preference. Health status appears to influence preferences through its impact on functional capacity, with the strongest effects observed in attributes linked to mobility and environmental access.

Taken together, the interaction models reveal a pattern of selective rather than pervasive preference heterogeneity. Observable socio-demographic characteristics, namely age, gender, and health, explain some but limited variation in residential preferences, while

the mixed logit random parameters capture substantial unobserved heterogeneity that these characteristics do not fully account for. The most consistent finding across all three interaction dimensions is that mobility-related attributes, particularly public transport access, are more sensitive to individual circumstances than amenity preferences such as green space and shops, which remain broadly valued across subgroups. This pattern has practical relevance: it suggests that while the general case for neighbourhood accessibility is robust across the older adult population, transport provision may need to be more carefully tailored to subgroup needs, particularly for those in poorer health and advanced age. These results align with evidence from the United States and the Netherlands (Caplan et al., 2021; Ossokina & Arentze, 2022), while contributing new evidence from a Scandinavian context where empirical valuation studies remain limited. The present study extends this literature by incorporating both renters and homeowners and by focusing on individuals actively considering relocation, which strengthens the behavioural relevance of the stated preference data.

From a policy perspective, the results highlight the importance of integrating housing, transport, and land-use planning to support older adults. Both public and private transport access play a critical role in sustaining autonomy, regardless of age, gender, or health. The income gradients implicit in MWTP differences across tenure groups also highlight the risk that market mechanisms may exacerbate spatial inequality, limiting access to well-located housing for lower-income older adults. Policies that preserve affordability and tenure diversity in high-amenity locations are therefore important to avoid reinforcing socioeconomic segregation in later life. Improving the accessibility and usability of green environments, through level pathways, seating, lighting, and safe crossings, may further help ensure that the wellbeing benefits of green space remain available across the ageing spectrum.

Limitations

Several limitations warrant consideration. The study sample comprises individuals already registered for relocation services. Although this can be viewed as a strength, since these individuals are actively considering relocation and may therefore give more

thoughtful responses to hypothetical housing choices, they may differ from the broader older population in terms of motivation or socioeconomic characteristics. The sample is also skewed toward higher levels of educational attainment, which limits the generalizability of the findings. The attribute set focuses primarily on locational factors and does not capture dwelling-level characteristics such as size, accessibility, or interior adaptability. The choice of attributes reflects priorities identified in the existing literature and from the broader RELOC-AGE study, but other attributes relevant to older adults, such as neighbourhood safety, social infrastructure, or dwelling adaptability, were not included and may also shape relocation preferences in meaningful ways. The monetary estimates are context-specific and may not generalise across different housing markets or welfare contexts.

Finally, the cross-sectional design precludes an assessment of how preferences evolve over time. Future research would benefit from longitudinal and mixed-method approaches to better capture how changes in health, financial, and social circumstances shape residential choices across the ageing process.

Conclusion

This study demonstrates that neighbourhood accessibility emerges as a central determinant of housing choice among older adults in Sweden. Proximity to shops, services, green space, and public transport consistently increases residential utility, as does access to dedicated parking, though the relative importance of these attributes varies by tenure, age, gender, and health status. Homeowners expressed substantially higher willingness to pay across all attributes, a pattern that likely reflects differences in financial resources, housing equity, and the investment orientation associated with ownership. That renters display economically meaningful but systematically lower valuations across all attributes points to the risk that market mechanisms may limit access to well-located housing for lower-income older adults, reinforcing spatial inequality in later life.

Observable socio-demographic characteristics explain only a modest share of preference variation. Where subgroup differences do emerge, they are concentrated in mobility-related attributes, particularly public transport access, which is more sensitive to age and health status than preferences for green space or shops, which remain broadly stable

across groups. This suggests that while the general case for neighbourhood accessibility is robust across the older adult population, transport provision warrants particular attention as a policy lever for supporting autonomy among those in poorer health and advanced age.

For policymakers and planners, the findings reinforce the importance of integrating housing, transport, and land-use planning in support of older adults. Age-friendly housing strategies should prioritize neighbourhood context alongside dwelling design, ensuring that accessible housing is located within reasonable distances of essential services and green spaces. Policies that preserve affordability and tenure diversity in high-amenity locations are equally important to avoid reinforcing socioeconomic segregation in later life.

Beyond its substantive contributions, the study illustrates the value of discrete choice methods for analysing housing decisions among ageing populations. By quantifying trade-offs and preference heterogeneity, the approach provides actionable evidence to support more inclusive and equitable housing strategies. As the global population continues to age, recognising and planning for the diversity of later-life residential preferences becomes increasingly important for supporting independence, wellbeing, and social inclusion.

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